MEMOIR OF MY LIFE

ARTHUR LAZARUS

28.01.1886 – 3.01.1957



9/1948

Stargard, Pomerania – a District Town of approximately 30,000 inhabitants and, since the end of the Second World War, once more ceded to Poland – was my place of birth. By the Ina, a little river running into the Dammschen Lake, the town boasted medieval walls with iron gate and churches in the Gothic style, all of which caused it to be called "the Pomeranian Nuernberg".

Born in 1886, my childhood and school years fell into the last decade of the 19th century. Looking back I have to say that 'those good old days' were barely touched by the imminent 20th century. The sleepy, musty atmosphere of that era was reflected in the people. Several decades of peace under the Hohenzollen* and fertile land producing first rate foodstuff, caused the people of the region to be lethargic and unresponsive to the progress of the world. Only reluctantly did they partake in the achievements of civilization.

* the rulers of Prussia, Northern Germany



Geburts-Schein.

Nur gültig in Angelegenheiten des Heeresersatzes.

Vor- und Zuname: Arthur Lazarus

Geburtstag und Ort: 28. Januar 1886. Stargard i/Pom.

Vor- und Zuname, sowie Stand des Vaters: Oscar Lazarus, Kaufmann

Vor- und Zuname der Mutter: Henriette geborene Aron

(Ort) Stargard i/Pom. den 4. im Dezember 1905.

Der Standesbeamte.

Kühne

Copy of birth certificate of Arthur issued on 4.12.1905

Stargard at that time was home to 125 Jewish families, about 500 souls. This community was assimilated in as much as it shared the comfort and lack of enterprise of the people among whom they lived. These characteristics may also have been due to the predominantly agricultural nature of the province which made for conservative attitudes.

The Royal Gymnasium (High School) attended by both my brothers and I and most of the sons of the town's Jews, was catering for the sons of "gentlemen farmers", landowners, the sons of senior civil servants and officers. The curriculum of the1890's had been largely unchanged since the seventies of that century. Apart from a few middle-aged teachers who were more or less modern, the teaching staff consisted of old and ancient professors of a dead

Age. Nonetheless a breath of liberal humanism blew through the establishment which tolerated neither racism nor anti-Semitism. However, socially these were noticeable under the surface.

My father arrived in 1879 from Birmingham, England, in order to marry my mother in Stargard. He was born in Vilna, Russia, which he had to leave in order to avoid life as a Russian soldier – the fate of the second sons of all Jewish families under the czars. My father spent about seven years in England where he saved enough money to buy a house in Stargard. From this new home he ran a small business of selling articles of men's clothing, mainly for farmers. He also traded in watches, gold and silver objects which he bought at auctions. My father lived in that town until his death in 1935 and was known to be an honourable, sound businessman and his customers belonged to the best circles.





Henriette & Aron Lazarus

Henriette Gitel born **Loewe**
5.10.1853 – 13.01.1893

Aron Uriel Lazarus
18.07.1851 – 6.02.1935

My mother died at the age of 40 in 1893 having suffered from cancer of the colon for seven years. My father was 83 when he died.

From the age of two to nine the years of my mother's illness I was brought up by her half-brother and his wife, Uncle Aron and Aunt Bertha Will. They had no children of their own and spoilt me very much. Aged nine I returned to my parental home after my father had re-married. I shan't go into details about the following six years until I finished school. I never received the love and care which my wife bestowed on our three children. I would not claim that this somewhat unloving period of my childhood affected my development. Perhaps quite the opposite. Although when I started a business

apprenticeship in Berlin I was only 15 years old I never longed to be back in my parental home. I had not been conscious during those six years of a lack of emotional support. Only later did I realize that the years of development are of the utmost importance in adult life. But in those days no one either at home or at school concerned themselves with the needs and problems of youngsters growing up. Psycho-analysis had not yet been invented.

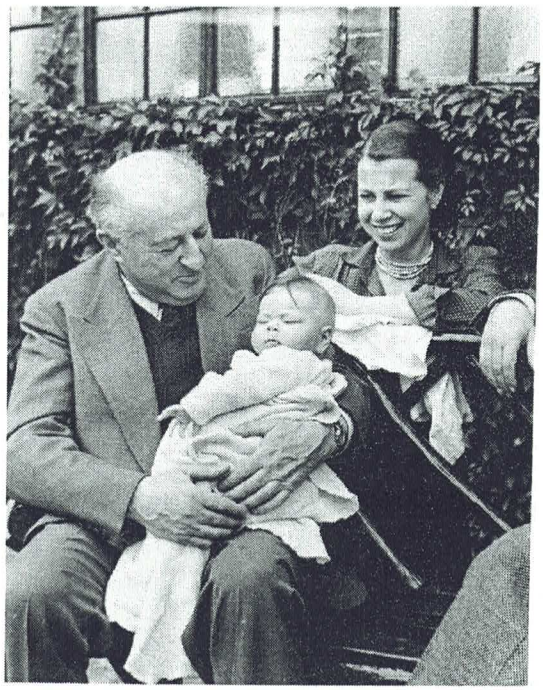
APPRENTICESHIP AND BACHELOR YEARS

In Berlin I received my first professional polish in the firm where I also absorbed the meaning of being a reputable businessman. An inborn business instinct – without possessing special talents in any particular field – helped me to do the right thing professionally from early on. Later it was said that I had a "sense of the essential". This compliment I accepted gladly. Twelve successful years followed:- wonderful holidays by the Baltic and North Sea; Denmark, German mountain regions but especially the Alps through which I travelled on foot and by coach from the eastern Tyrol to the western Swiss Mont Blanc area.



A horse drawn coach traveling the Alps circa. 1900

Those were the years before the motor car disturbed the idyllic nature of the Alps. Yellow stage coaches drawn by three or four horses travelled in convoy and gentle rhythm up and down the famous alpine passes such as Furka and Grimsel as well as through the Rhone Valley. During my flight to England in 1951 I marveled that it took just a few minutes to cross the Alps. These early journeys with meager funds remained unforgetable memories throughout my life. Later trips with my wife and rather more money at my disposal opened up the grandeur of the alpine peaks.



Visit to London 1951
L-R: Arthur, Brigitte with Jennifer (6 months old)

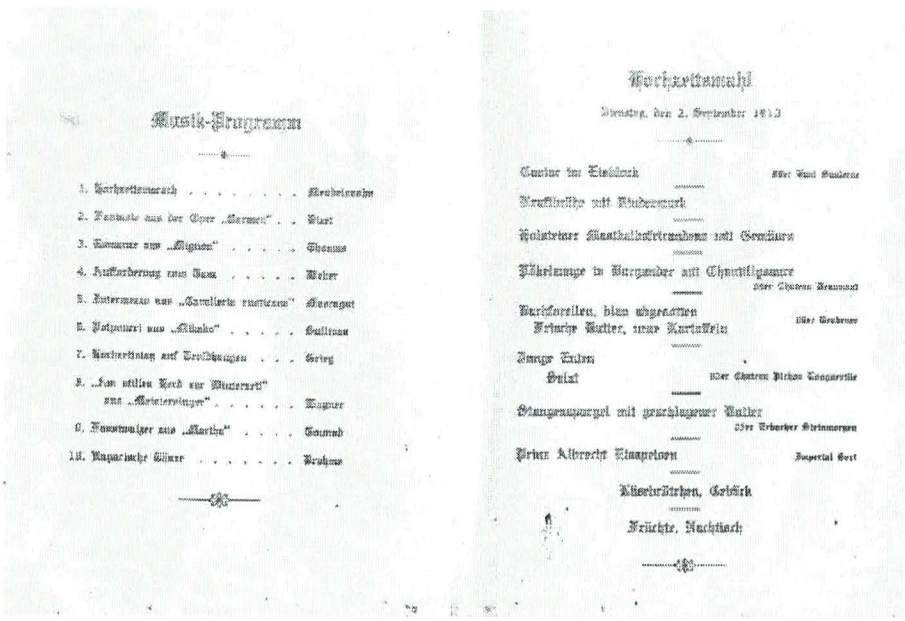
Though I was not particularly good at sports I belonged to a gymnastics club and later a rowing club. But mountaineering in the Alps was my favourite. Cycling, skiing and even boxing for a short while all ended in total failure. During my business trips I got to know western Germany and at an early age most parts of the country.

THE TIME PRIOR TO WORLD WAR ONE

In 1913, aged 27, I married my 20-year old wife. Two years previously I had joined Leonard Tietz AG company and – newly married and full of hope – life stretched before me. But in the summer of 1914 during a Czech holiday in Spindlermuehle the news of the murder of the Austrian heir to the throne (Habsburg) hit us like a bolt from heaven. It was the beginning of an unholy period of wars which even now, 40 years later, has not ended.



Arthur & Kaete on their wedding day 2.9.1913



Musik-Programm

1. Hochzeitsmarsch . . . . . Mendelssohn
2. Fantasie aus der Oper „Carmen" . . Bizet
3. Romanze aus „Mignon" . . . . . Thomas
4. Aufforderung zum Tanz . . . . . Weber
5. Intermezzo aus „Cavalleria rusticana" Mascagni
6. Potpourri aus „Rikako" . . . . . Gallinus
7. Norwegisch auf Troldhaugen . . . Grieg
8. „Am stillen Herd zu Winterszeit" aus „Meistersinger" . . . . . Wagner
9. Feuerreiter aus „Martha" . . . . Gounod
10. Ungarische Tänze . . . . . Brahms

Hochzeitsmahl

Dienstag, den 2. September 1913

Cocktail im Eisblock — Über Eis Gekühlt

Kraftbrühe mit Markeinlage

Holsteiner Matjeshäringsfilets mit Gemüse

Filetsteak in Burgunder mit Champignonsauce — Über Chafing Dish

Backforellen, blau abgekocht, Frische Butter, neue Kartoffeln — Über Gasbrenner

Junge Enten, Salat — Über Chafing Dish Tafelgeräte

Stangenspargel mit geschlagener Butter — Über Heizbarer Spirituskocher

Prinz Albrecht Eisspeisen — Imperial Eis

Käsestangen, Gebäck

Früchte, Nachtisch

The wedding menu and music program

Wedding Menu
Tuesday, 2. September 1913

Caviar on Ice	1899 Sauterne
Consome with Bone Marrow	
Veal in a White Cream Sauce with Vegetables	
Pickled Ox Tongue in a Burgundy Cream Sauce	1909 Chateau Bemont (red)
River Trout "bleu" with Butter & new Potatoes	1909 Trabener (white)
Duckling – Salad	1902 Chateau Pichon Liongueville
Asparagus with Whipped Butter	1905 Erbacher Steinmorgen
Prince Albrecht Ice Creams	Imperial Champagne
Little cheese rolls, biscuits/cookies Fruit - Dessert	

Music Program

1. Wedding March	Mendelssohn
2. Carmen	Bizet
3. "Romance" from Mignon	Thomas
4. Invitation to a Dance	Weber
5. Intermezzo from Cavalleria Rusticana	Mascagni
6. Potpourri from The Mikado	Sir Arthur Sullivan
7. Wedding Day at Troldhangen	Grieg
8. Meistersinger	Wagner
9. Walz from "Martha"	Gounod
10.Hungarian Dances	Brahms

We had grown up during a 44 – year epoch of peace and had no idea of the horrors of war and the problems of a **lost** war which led to and included Nazism. Thus the carefree time from when we married to when war broke out lasted a mere eleven months and gave way to serious times.

WAR YEARS 1914 – 1918

The first blow to our family came when in January 1915 we received news of the death of my wife's brother, Hans Wolff. He was the first of his Infantry Regiment Company to be hit by a fatal bullet. He was only 20 years old.



Hans Wolff 5.01.1895 – 14.01.1915

A few months before that our first son, Walter, was born on 22 September 1914. In April 1915 I was called up and joined the Artillery – far from Berlin. I was sent to Koenigsberg in East Prussia. I was parted from my family for nearly four years though interspersed with army leave and visits from my wife. She was left with a 7-months old baby in our new, modern apartment opposite theTreptower Park in East Berlin, near the river Spree.

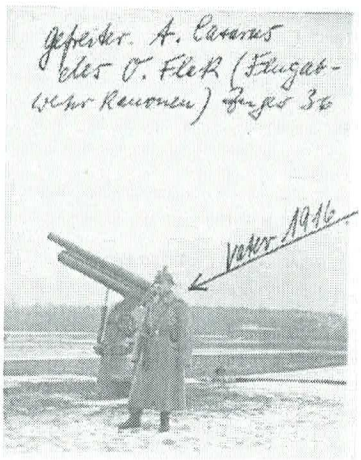


Walter - 1915

I don't wish to go into details of my war memories. Suffice it to say that I was stationed in Karlsruhe in Baden for more than three years until the beginning of the November 1918 Revolution except for two tours of duty on the German-Belgian front at Ostende and Blankenberghe. Well-meaning officers, nice comrades, safe and pleasant duties all contributed to more than bearable war years. My immediate superior, Major Benno Kalau vom Hofe, showed me goodwill and particularly friendly feelings which lasted well into our post-war civilian life.









Arthur – WORLD WAR ONE 1916

Without deserving it I received the medal for Frontline Duties (Frontkaempfer-kreuz), though I witnessed not a single war casualty in our group during those four years.

I received a second medal for War Effort, ostensibly for successful propaganda for war loans (Kriegsanleihe) . This was coupled with special leave.



Besitzeugnis

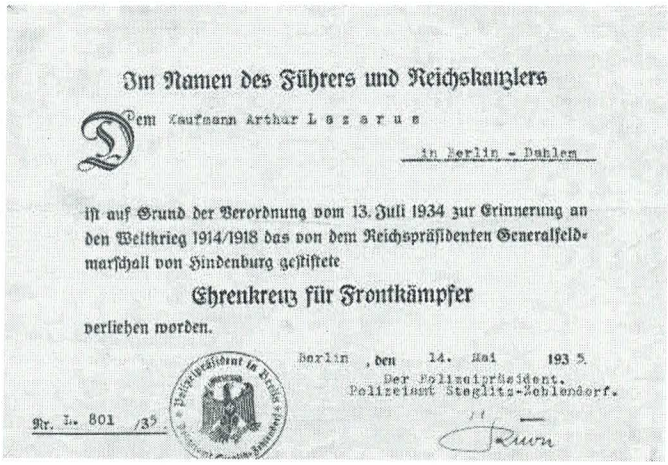
Auf Allerhöchsten Befehl Seiner Majestät des Königs bezeugt die Generalkommission in Angelegenheiten der Königlich Preußischen Orden hierdurch, daß Seine Majestät dem

Gefreiten Lazarus
des O. Flak.-Zuges 56

das Verdienstkreuz für Kriegshilfe zu verleihen geruht haben.

Berlin, den 1. Juli 917.

Generalkommission in Angelegenheiten der Königlich Preußischen Orden



Im Namen des Führers und Reichskanzlers

Dem Kaufmann Arthur L a z a r u s

in Berlin - Dahlem

ist auf Grund der Verordnung vom 13. Juli 1934 zur Erinnerung an den Weltkrieg 1914/1918 das von dem Reichspräsidenten Generalfeldmarschall von Hindenburg gestiftete

Ehrenkreuz für Frontkämpfer

verliehen worden.

Berlin , den 14. Mai 193 5.

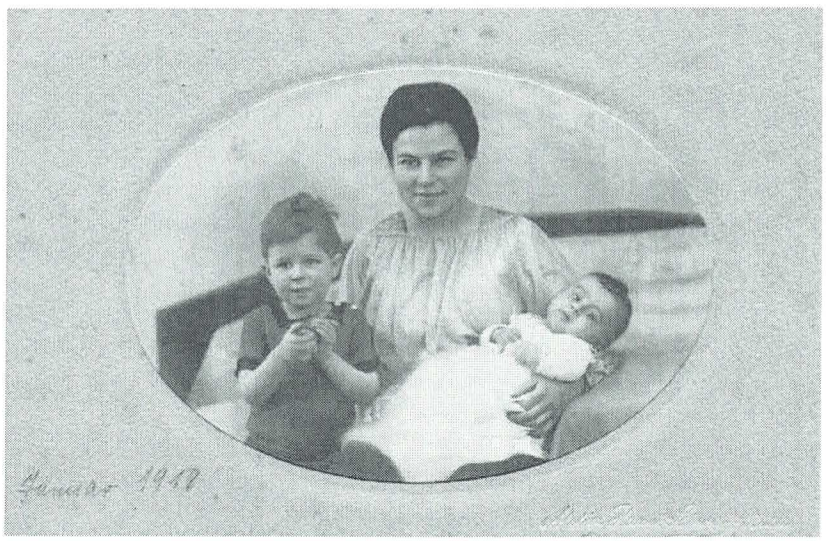
Der Polizeipräsident
Polizeiamt Steglitz-Zehlendorf.

Nr. L. 801 /35



Certificates and Medals for Effort and War Loans

The proximity of the Black Forest tempted me to take frequent trips there on days off duty in Karlsruhe. Meantime our son, Kurt, was born on July 3rd 1917 and the following summer my wife brought the two small children for a prolonged stay at Herrenalp where I could visit them often. Despite food shortage caused by the blockade of Germany and the general wartime emergency, my four years as a soldier were by and large carefree and in many ways an experience which widened my horizon.

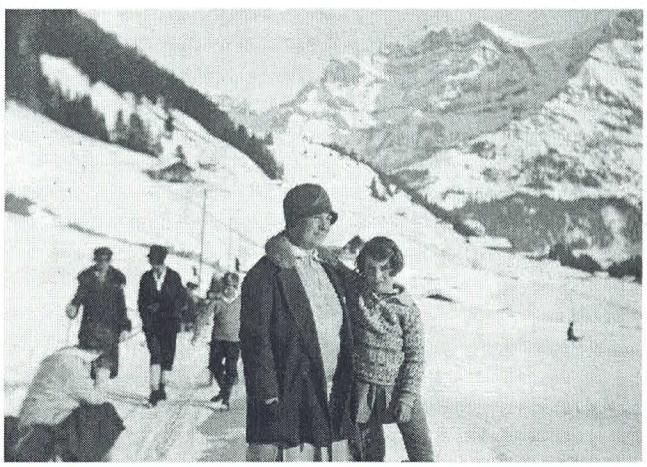


L-R: Walter, Kaete & Kurt - 1918

REVOLUTION AND INFLATION

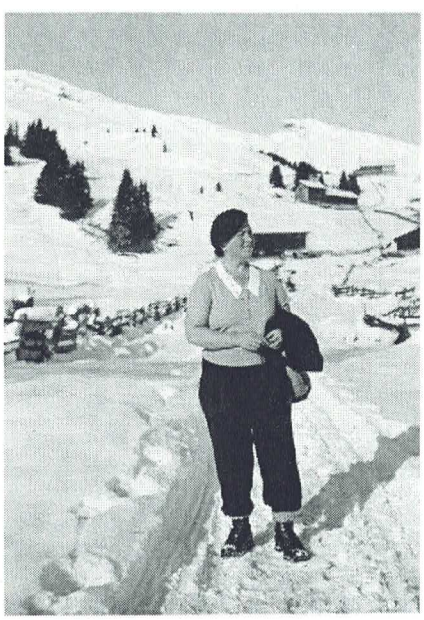
The war ended in Germany's total defeat, sealed by the Soldiers' Revolution. I returned to Berlin that November and at last began a normal family life. The German economy was in ruins as a result of lack of raw materials. That is also how we found our once blossoming company Leonard Tietz in November 1918. What appeared like a short period of prosperity was interrupted by the madest of all inflations until, in 1924, there was an upturn in our company.

Our life style at that time though modest was one of our best periods ever because of uncomplicated hiking holidays, the joys of the countryside and tours of the Alps. I shall not go into details here about my successful business career during the next few years as that is not the idea of this memoir.

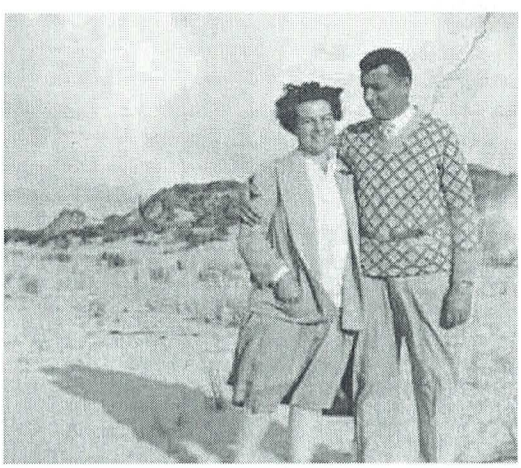




With Brigitte in Adelboden 1929



Kaete – Lenzerheide 1934



Kaete & Arthur – Norderney 1927
(an Island in the North Sea)

EVER FORWARD AND UPWARD TO THE DOWNFALL

During the creeping inflation of 1921 I managed to buy a plot of land in Dahlem, one of the most beautiful western suburbs of Berlin. We built our house here and lived in it from December 1922 until we left Germany.



The house in Dahlem Summer 1925

Ownership of a car, the expenses of which were met by the company, made life as magnificent as we could never have imagined in our wildest dreams. My wife undertook the care of the garden and our daughter, Brigitte, born on 20 June 1922 while we still lived in Treptow, spent her entire childhood in this beautiful house and garden.

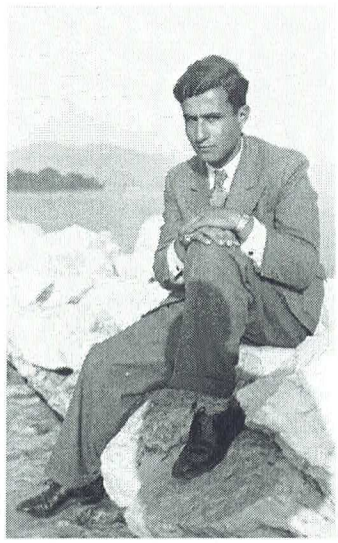


Kaete with Brigitte - 1923

The sons attended the Arndt Gymnasium nearby in Dahlem where they participated in everything this fine school had to offer, especially sports. Our well-ordered home was an attraction for friends and family.

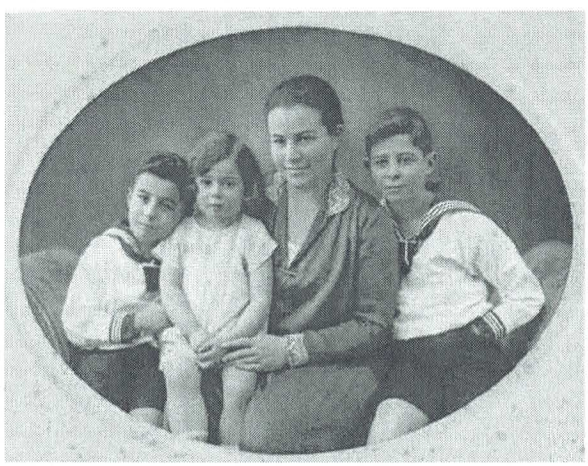


Walter – Madonna di Campiglio 1931



Kurt –Geneva 1933

Wonderful holidays with our without the children, by car or by railway were the highlight during those 'upward' years. Our life was running smoothly. The orchard part of the garden kept us amply supplied with fruit throughout the year – apples, pears, plums, peaches, raspberries, strawberries, gooseberries and redcurrants – and a small pool for the children were the fulfilment of our dreams. It could hardly get better until the year 1933 heralded the beginning of the end of all the splendour.

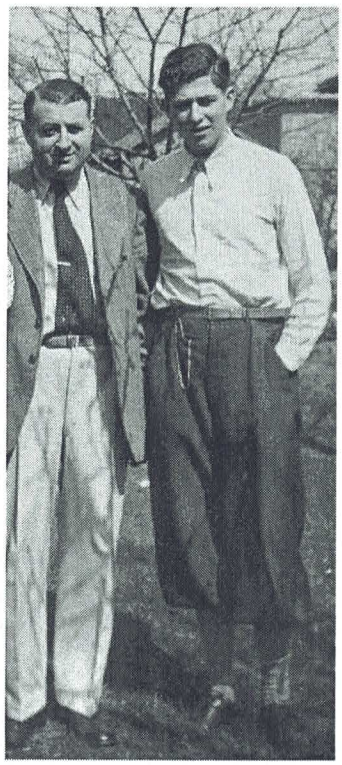


L-R : Kurt , Brigitte, Kaete & Walter– Dahlem 1924



Walter & Brigitte with their grandmother , Johanna Wolff 'Oti' Dahlem -1933

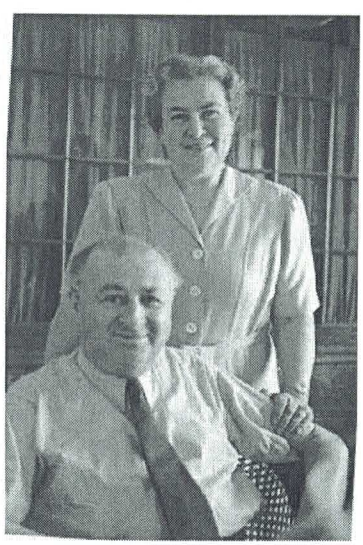
Walter had passed the Abitur (final school exams) that spring and was given a ski holiday as a reward. He was to start his apprenticeship with the Reichsbahn (state-run railways) when, in April '33, our life took a different turn altogether.



With Walter – Dahlem 1934

ZIONISM AND PESSIMISM

The ignominious First of April 1933 showed me that in Germany there was no future any longer for our children. Decisions had to be made.
Just as the war years saved me from death and injury so for about four years until the day of our emigration, I was spared the dangers I was exposed to as the director of a large manufacturing concern. We turned our back on the horror regime unfolding and began immediately in '33 to plan our departure in November 1936.
Our sons joined Zionist youth movements which helped restore their equilibrium. Brigitte transferred to a Zionist school in Berlin. Walter first went to Chemnitz (eastern Germany) and then to Winterthur near Zuerich for mechanical engineering training. Kurt joined an agricultural training scheme (Hachsharah) on a farm in Holland.
Palestine, a British mandate at the time seemed a tempting option as a new home. So in September 1933 my wife and I sailed to the Middle East on the SS Roma for a reconnaissance trip. Palestine had many shortcomings:- most everything seemed 'unfinished', the climate hardly bearable during the summer months and the countryside looked very 'foreign' to us. But many like-minded people began to go there from Germany. Life was cheap; it was an oasis of low taxes; and it was far from the country which with its racial hate campaign threatened to infect all of Europe. The second World War confirmed our worst fears.
We settled in Tel-Aviv. The sons had joined Kibuzim. Brigitte attended school and went to England in 1938 for further education. In '39 she returned just as the second World War broke out. She 'matriculated' (University of London Matric for External Students) and then got a job with Barclays Bank (then D.C. &O) in Jerusalem. On her pleading we moved there from Tel-Aviv. With a large circle of old and new friends we lived in Jerusalem from 1941-1949.



Jerusalem 1947

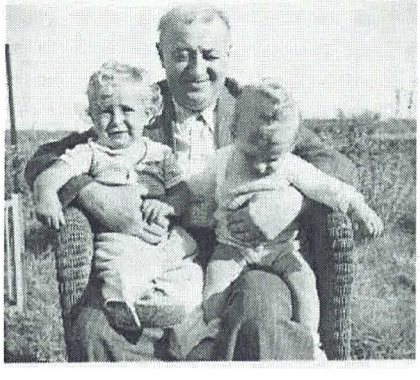
I never returned to professional work as I had sufficient financial where-withal not to get involved hastily in risky opportunities.

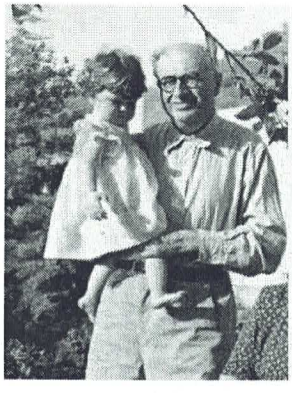
Looking back I have no regrets when I observe how many undertakings ended in bankruptcy. An important factor in my decision was that neither son had the inclination or ability to build a new livelihood with me.

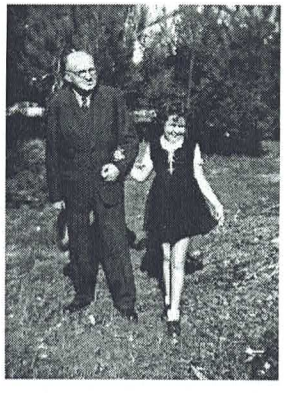
The Jewish-Arab war which caused Jerusalem to be entirely cut off from the rest of the Jewish part of Palestine and which resulted in water and food shortages were difficult months indeed. Our sons, especially Walter, urged us to move to Shaar Hefer where we finally built a nice little bungalow and could have led a tranquil existence. But an eye operation (Glaucoma) and other age-related complaints made rural life difficult for me and my wife never quite came to terms with it.



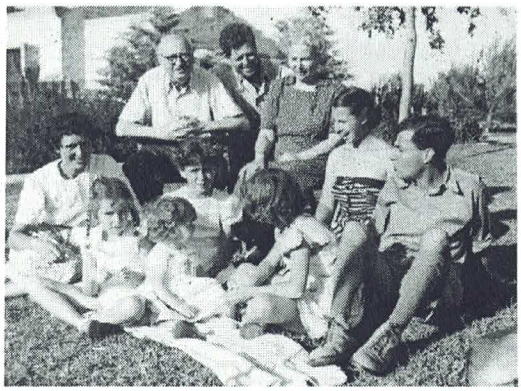
The house in Shaar Hefer - 1950

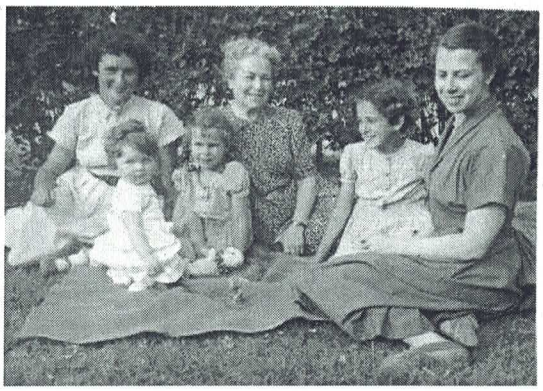






Arthur with his four granddaughters
L-R: Ilana , Noemi , Jennifer & Gabi





A family reunion – Shaar Hefer 1952

The State of Israel with its unrestrained immigration policy and senseless inflation brought the young state to the brink of economic breakdown. An inherent beggars' (schnorrer) mentality caused or causes the government to spend spend spend – always in the expectation that the American Jews 'won't let us down". I could never understand why not. The prudent elements of the State lost their savings. That is to say, any savings they still had were reduced to a fraction of their former value. Add to that the ever-present fear of a new-possibly atomic- world war and our local worry of peace, withheld by the Arab countries around us. All this converted me from Zionism to pessimism despite the fact which I accept gratefully, that for 63 years I enjoyed good health, lived in harmony with my wife for 40 years, lost none of my three children and was spared from poverty. I hope fate is merciful and I retain sufficient eye sight to be able to write.

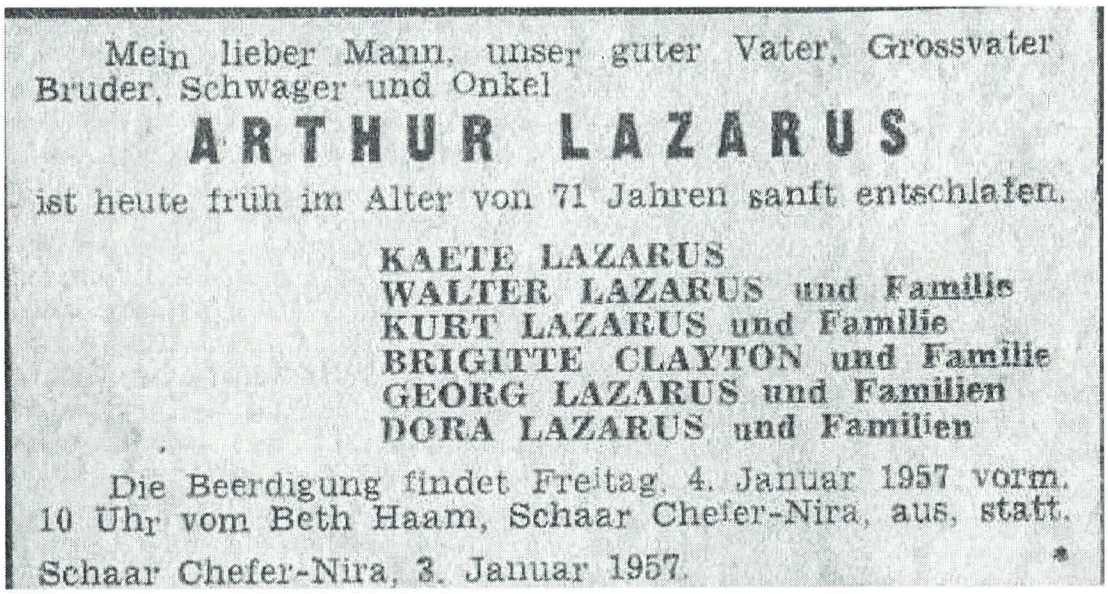
I am after all 67 years old and must not quarrel with fate which took me from modest beginnings through decades of rising fortunes. I was spared the dangers of wars, revolution and persecution. All members of our immediate family had been saved through firm and timely decisions.

My wife and I have always endeavoured to prepare our children for life's challenges and to afford them the best education available under the circumstances – perhaps the advantages were too many in some respect. They grew up as 'second generation' and thus took for granted much in their parental home. Objectively seen this may have spoilt them too much. That was of course not their fault. They can only follow their road through life by, as Goethe said,".....dem Gesetz nach dem sie angetreten". **

** "....as their destiny ordained".

I shall end with the wish that we shall be spared being a burden to our children. If so, I shall patiently carry the burden of getting old as long as my maker intends.

Arthur Lazarus, Shaar Hefer, 7 July 1953



Mein lieber Mann, unser guter Vater, Grossvater, Bruder, Schwager und Onkel

ARTHUR LAZARUS

ist heute früh im Alter von 71 Jahren sanft entschlafen.

KAETE LAZARUS
WALTER LAZARUS und Familie
KURT LAZARUS und Familie
BRIGITTE CLAYTON und Familie
GEORG LAZARUS und Familien
DORA LAZARUS und Familien

Die Beerdigung findet Freitag, 4. Januar 1957 vorm. 10 Uhr vom Beth Haam, Schaar Chefer-Nira, aus, statt.

Schaar Chefer-Nira, 3. Januar 1957.

Translated by: Brigitte Paterson April 2006

The photos were added by Ilana Maik April 2006